

The Paper: Jesse Crosson and Jaclyn Kaslovsky, 2024. “Do Local Roots Impact Washington Behaviors? District Connections and Representation in the U.S. Congress”

In this paper, Crosson and Kaslovsky argue that having local roots (being born in one's district) boosts a legislator's descriptive representation, and as a result, voters expect them to prioritize district service over service to their party or even national policymaking. They find that legislators with local roots are more likely to focus on issues in their district rather than national or party politics, allocate a higher percentage of their staff to constituency service, and are more likely to have bipartisan cosponsors. However, these legislators are not more or less likely to vote with their party on roll call votes. The findings suggest that a geographical connection to one's district contributes to descriptive representation and encourages district-focused political behavior.

Basic Replication

Running the regressions on the dataset yielded results identical to those reported in the paper. As an example, the results of the two multinomial logistic regressions are below.

	(Intercept)	binary	dem	seniority	majority	power	chair
District Focused	4.841	0.758	-0.242	0.041	-0.446	-0.023	-1.165
Policy Focused	-2.323	0.535	0.043	0.036	-0.078	0.095	-0.637
	female	inpres					
District Focused	0.092	-10.501					
Policy Focused	0.136	2.078					

	(Intercept)	logged_distance	dem	seniority	majority	power
District Focused	5.519	-0.127	-0.247	0.041	-0.448	-0.006
Policy Focused	-1.860	-0.073	0.055	0.035	-0.077	0.112
	chair	female	inpres			
District Focused	-1.186	0.146	-10.585			
Policy Focused	-0.667	0.168	1.963			

We agree with the authors' choice of models. First, a multinomial logistic regression is appropriate to study the relationship between local roots and legislative style, because legislative style is a nominal variable with three factors: Party Focused, District Focused, and Policy Focused. This variable has no ordering or distance between each value.

Second, the authors used OLS to study the relationship between local roots and (1) percentage of staff allocated to constituency service, (2) party unity, and (3) cosponsorship. OLS is appropriate because these three dependent variables are continuous measures.

Running the Models on Time-Period Subsets

Although we agree with the model choices, it may be important to test the findings for robustness over subsets of the data. Specifically, some of the authors' models were run over a dataset of all US Congress members from 1973 to 2020. During that period, the "textbook Congress" decreased in salience as polarization and partisanship increased. It could be the case that the effects of polarization dilute the impact of local roots on legislative behavior in more recent Congresses.

To test this, we divided the dataset into three subsets—the 93-100th Congresses, the 101-108th Congresses, and the 109-116th Congresses—and ran the two cosponsorship models on each subset. The (abbreviated) results are shown below, next to the full dataset results.

Variable	<i>Dependent variable: Percent of Cosponsors that are Copartisans</i>							
	1973–2020		93rd–100th		101st–108th		109th–116th	
	binary	log	binary	log	binary	log	binary	log
Born in District	–0.030** (0.007)		–0.041** (0.013)		–0.038** (0.016)		–0.012 (0.012)	
Logged Distance		0.004** (0.001)		0.009** (0.002)		0.005** (0.003)		0.001 (0.002)
Democrat	0.124** (0.007)	0.123** (0.007)	0.125** (0.014)	0.123** (0.014)	0.084** (0.016)	0.083** (0.016)	0.106** (0.012)	0.106** (0.012)
Seniority	–0.006** (0.001)	–0.006** (0.001)	–0.004** (0.001)	–0.004 (0.001)	–0.004** (0.001)	–0.004** (0.001)	–0.008** (0.001)	–0.008** (0.001)
District FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Congress FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	10,263	10,263	3,355	3,355	3,409	3,409	3,499	3,499
Adjusted R ²	0.463	0.463	0.407	0.408	0.424	0.424	0.470	0.470

As the table shows, in the subset containing the most recent Congresses in the data (109 to 116), the effect of local roots on partisan cosponsors is no longer significant, for both measures of local roots / distance. So it does seem that the relationship between having local roots and having bipartisan cosponsors is much weaker in the current polarized era.

We tried a similar test on the constituency service allocation model. The authors only had constituency service data for 1993–2014, so we divided the dataset into two groups, 1993–2002, and 2003–2013. The authors had found a significant positive relationship between local roots and percentage of staff allocated to constituency service. Interestingly, when regressing over these two periods, the relationship is only significant in the more recent period (which is the opposite of what we found for the cosponsor model).

These results suggest that the effect of having local roots on legislative behavior was not static throughout the period the authors studied. However, different measures of legislative behavior (cosponsorship and constituency service allocation) change differently.